REBELS, SECURITY FORCES, CIVILIANS: THE TRAIL OF BLOOD

JULY 10, 2019

BALAGHAT DISTRICT
Two Maoists, including a woman, killed

NOV. 7, 2020

MALAKHEDI, BALAGHAT
Woman Maoist cadre killed

DEC. 2020

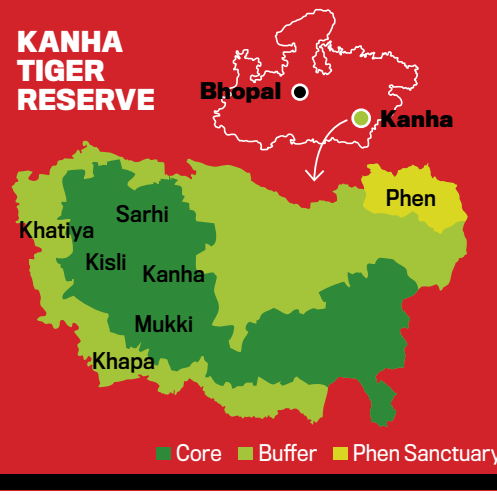
KIRNAPUR, BALAGHAT
Two women Maoist cadres killed

FEB. 12, 2021

MANDLA DISTRICT
Two Maoists, including a woman, killed

CIVILIANS KILLED BY MAOISTS

- **Bhagchand Adme**, resident of Bamhni, Balaghat, killed on suspicion of being a police informer on June 30, 2021
- **Jagdish and Santosh**, locals of Balaghat, killed on November 14, 2021
- **Sukhdeo**, forest chowkidar, killed in Mukki, Balaghat, on March 23, 2022



government—Rs 8 crore annually through the entry fee charged from tourists, and much more through indirect taxes paid by hotels and bars around Kanha, which was declared a sanctuary back in the 1930s and turned into a tiger reserve in 1973, immediately after the announcement of Project Tiger. Some 170,000 Indian and 15,000 foreign tourists visit Kanha every year, making it a major source of employment in the region. The reserve has around 85 wildlife lodges, 175 guides and 257 drivers, and a total of 100,000 work days are created through them annually. With forest staff scared of patrolling the reserve, wildlife, too could be at risk. After phase IV of the wildlife census in 2020, it was found that Kanha has 118 tigers and 146 leopards, besides 957 swamp deer found only in this reserve alongside more than 30,000 spotted deer.

Maoist presence inside Kanha also implies an expansion of territory under their influence. Though they have been spotted inside the reserve only recently, the guerrillas have been around in Balaghat district for three decades. Neighbouring Mandla and Dindori districts too have been designated as 'LWE (Left Wing Extremism)-affected'. The Maoists have largely kept a low profile, avoiding confrontations till matters came to a head with the forest chowkidar's killing, the third local death at their hands since November 2021. Police sources claim Balaghat residents Jagdish and Santosh were killed on November 14 as retribution for the killing of Sharda, a woman Maoist, by the Hawk Force—the MP government's anti-Maoist unit—a year ago. A day later, Milind Teltumbde, who headed the Maoists' Maharashtra-MP-Chhattisgarh (MMC) zone, was killed along with 26 others by Maharashtra Police's C-60 commando unit not far from Kanha. In the past two and a half years, seven Maoists with Rs 6-12 lakh bounties on their heads have been killed in MP. And, in the past one year, the state has seen over 15 exchanges of fire between Maoists and security forces.

SECURITY OFFICIALS SAY THEIR SUCCESS AGAINST MAOISTS HAS PUSHED THEM INTO KANHA

Security officials say their very success against Maoists has pushed the guerrillas into Kanha. "The encounters happened when Maoists visited villages on the reserve's periphery for food and supplies. So they seem to have decided to avoid those villages and are now sourcing their food after threatening forest staff in camps deep in the jungles," says a police officer. With no villages inside the reserve, there is hardly anyone to notice the Maoists unless they run into a forest department patrol, chances of which are growing slim these days.

The guerrillas in Kanha are from the MMC zone, which the outlawed CPI(Maoist) formed in 2015 to ease the pressure in Bastar where security forces have been closing in on them. With few locals in the ranks, most fighters are from Chhattisgarh and are now believed to be headed by a commander from Andhra Pradesh. Zeroing in on them won't be easy. For one, the Hawk Force has only around 800 personnel, who are already deployed in camps across Balaghat and Mandla. Moreover, while the Wildlife Protection Act, 1972, doesn't allow permanent constructions inside the reserve unless the Supreme Court's empowered committee permits it, police officers say they need all-weather roads for carrying out operations. "We have concerns about extraction of injured personnel and sending in reinforcements," says an officer.

Warning against complacency, a Hawk Force trooper posted in Balaghat says, "Maoists strengthen themselves in an area before starting operations. The relative peace can lull us into believing they are planning nothing big in Kanha, but that would amount to being in denial." He insists the time to act is now, before the situation gets out of hand. ■